

WEEK 1 - COMBINED STUDY GUIDE

Channel Theory: Concept, Nomenclature, Flow of Qi

Dr. Vivian Zhang (your registered instructor) + Dr. Justin Flinner (parallel section)

Print Edition

Read this first

Dr. Zhang is your registered AC300/AC375 instructor - her framing is what your own quizzes, midterm, and final will use. Dr. Flinner's material comes from a parallel section's transcripts and is included here as supplementary cross-reference, not as a substitute for Zhang's course.

This Guide Contains:

- The 12 Primary Meridians - full reference table (identical in both sources)
- Zhang's Three Circuits framework, with the real lecture-slide diagrams
- Direction-of-flow rules and the 4 meeting-point locations
- The Meridian Clock (both instructors teach the same 24-hour cycle)
- Where the two sources agree, and where their framing genuinely differs
- Flinner-only material: the Four Functions, Ying/Wei, Three Jiao, and the Two Pairing Systems

ZHANG SOURCE

AC300Week1.txt otter.ai transcript + lecture slides

FLINNER SOURCE

Flinner Week 1 otter.ai transcript (parallel section, no slides available)

Jon Centeno, D.AcHM Candidate | VUIM Summer 2026

What Both Instructors Confirm

Same textbook, same 12 channels - this table is identical in both sources

Agreement

BOTH

Both sources use the same 3-part naming convention (Hand/Foot + Yin/Yang + Zang/Fu), the same 12 meridians, and the same direction-of-flow rules. This table is safe to treat as universally exam-relevant, regardless of which section's quiz you're taking.

Ab	Name	Classification	Direction	Circuit
LU	Lung	Hand Taiyin	Chest -> Hand	Outer (Anterior)
LI	Large Intestine	Hand Yangming	Hand -> Head	Outer (Anterior)
ST	Stomach	Foot Yangming	Head -> Foot	Outer (Anterior)
SP	Spleen	Foot Taiyin	Foot -> Chest	Outer (Anterior)
HT	Heart	Hand Shaoyin	Chest -> Hand	Inner (Posterior)
SI	Small Intestine	Hand Taiyang	Hand -> Head	Inner (Posterior)
BL	Bladder	Foot Taiyang	Head -> Foot	Inner (Posterior)
KI	Kidney	Foot Shaoyin	Foot -> Chest	Inner (Posterior)
PC	Pericardium	Hand Jueyin	Chest -> Hand	Middle
SJ	San Jiao (Triple Burner)	Hand Shaoyang	Hand -> Head	Middle
GB	Gallbladder	Foot Shaoyang	Head -> Foot	Middle
LR	Liver	Foot Jueyin	Foot -> Chest	Middle

Direction-of-Flow Rules

Yin meridians of the HAND

Yang meridians of the HAND

Yang meridians of the FOOT

Yin meridians of the FOOT

Chest -> Hand

Hand -> Head

Head -> Foot

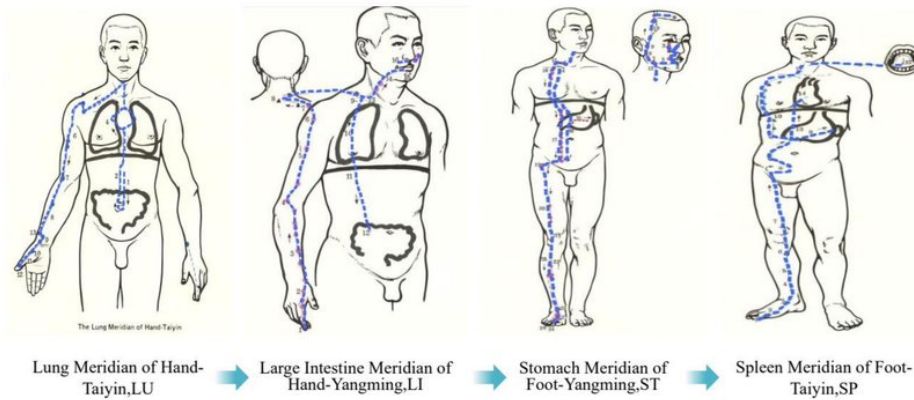
Foot -> Chest/Abdomen

Zhang's Three Circuits Framework

Groups all 12 channels into 3 circuits of 4 - the primary organizing structure for your own course

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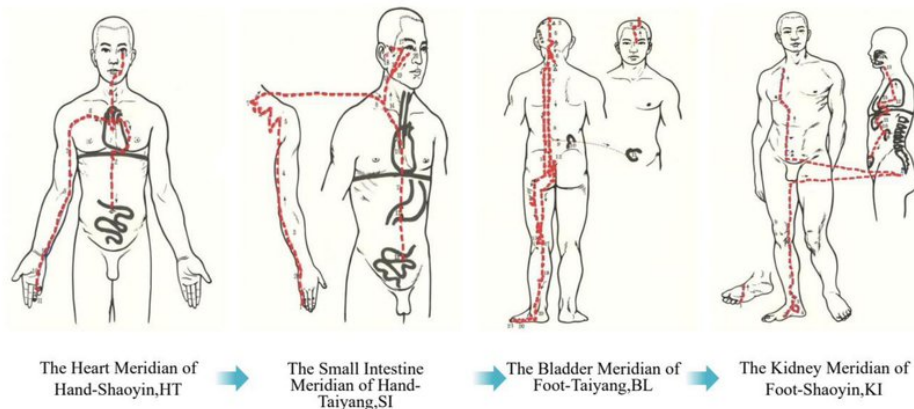
The Anterior Circuit



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The Anterior Circuit - Source: Dr. Zhang's Week 1 lecture slides

The Posterior Circuit

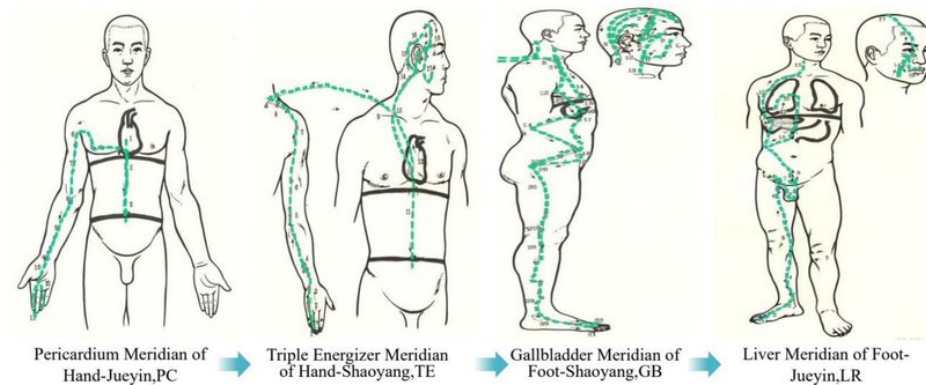


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The Posterior Circuit (also called Inner Circuit) - Source: Dr. Zhang's Week 1 lecture slides

Zhang's Three Circuits, continued

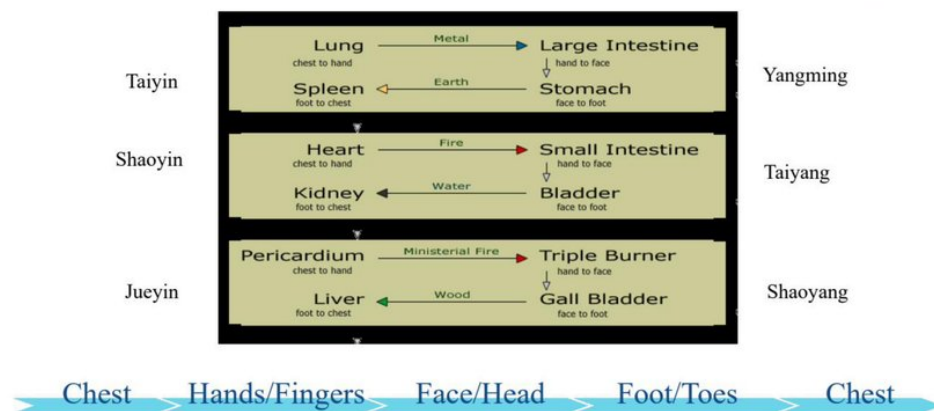
The Middle Circuit



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The Middle Circuit - Source: Dr. Zhang's Week 1 lecture slides

Three Main Circuits in the Flow of Qi



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Three Main Circuits Summary - Source: Dr. Zhang's Week 1 lecture slides

Not used by Flinner

FLINNER

Flinner's available transcripts introduce each Six-Meridian pair individually as its two member channels come up in sequence, rather than grouping all four-channel circuits together up front. No Three Circuits macro-structure appears in the Flinner Week 1 transcript.

Meeting Points & The Meridian Clock

Both instructors teach the same 24-hour circulation cycle

- BOTH**
- Hand Yin meets Hand Yang -> at the FINGERS**
e.g. LU7's branch meets LI1 at the index finger
 - Hand Yang meets Foot Yang -> at the FACE**
e.g. LI ends at LI20, ST begins there
 - Foot Yang meets Foot Yin -> at the TOES**
e.g. ST ends at ST45, SP begins at SP1
 - Foot Yin meets Hand Yin -> at the CHEST**
completes the full 12-channel loop back to the next circuit

The Meridian Clock - All 12 Channels

Channel	Peak Window
LU	3-5 AM
LI	5-7 AM
ST	7-9 AM
SP	9-11 AM
HT	11 AM-1 PM
SI	1-3 PM

Channel	Peak Window
BL	3-5 PM
KI	5-7 PM
PC	7-9 PM
SJ	9-11 PM
GB	11 PM-1 AM
LR	1-3 AM

Clinical pearl - using the clock

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Dr. Zhang's own clinical example: if you want to treat a Large Intestine dysfunction, consider timing treatment around 5-7 AM, LI's active period. Symptoms that flare at a specific time of day can point directly to which channel is involved.

The full system, at a glance

BOTH

Beyond the 12 Primary Meridians, the full channel system both sources describe includes: 15 Collaterals (the 12 primary Luo points, plus the Luo of Du Mai, Ren Mai, and the Spleen's Great Luo/Dabao), 12 Divergent Meridians, 12 Muscle/Sinew Regions, 12 Cutaneous Regions, and 8 Extraordinary Vessels - full detail on each arrives in later weeks.

The Functions of Channels & Points

Same underlying idea, different number of buckets – know both framings

Zhang - Three Functions

ZHANG

1. Transporting – carries Qi and Blood to nourish organs, skin, muscles, tendons, and bones; keeps Yin-Yang in harmony.
2. Resisting (Defending) – defends against disease and reflects symptoms/signs when something is wrong.
3. Treatment – transmits needling sensation and regulates deficiency and excess conditions.

Flinner - Four Functions

FLINNER

1. Transportation – moves Qi and Blood to maintain homeostasis, understood through Ying (nutritive, interior) and Wei (defensive, exterior) qi.
2. Defense – resistance to external pathogenic factors (wind, cold, summer-heat, dampness) and internal factors (emotions become pathogenic only when they overwhelm the system).
3. Transmission of De Qi – the arrival of qi: a mild ache or gentle tension (not pain) signaling the needle has engaged the channel.
4. Rectification of Imbalances – the treatment function: using channels and points to correct excess, deficiency, or blockage once diagnosed.

How to reconcile them

BOTH

These aren't contradictory – Flinner's #1 (Transportation) and #3 (Transmission of De Qi) together cover roughly the same ground as Zhang's #1 (Transporting) and #3 (Treatment). Flinner's Ying/Wei lens and his explicit De Qi/needling-sensation function are the two genuinely new pieces not spelled out in Zhang's Week 1 framing.

Flinner-Only: Ying/Wei & the Three Jiao

Not covered in Zhang's available Week 1 transcript - useful supplementary framing

FLINNER

Term	Domain	Function
Ying qi	Interior	Nutritive - nourishes organs and tissues via circulation
Wei qi	Exterior	Defensive - protects against external pathogenic invasion
Zang	Solid organs	Yin organ systems (e.g. Lung, Heart, Spleen)
Fu	Hollow organs	Yang organ systems (e.g. Large Intestine, Stomach, Small Intestine)

Flinner's framing note

Every organ system can be viewed through more than one lens at once: zang/fu, yin/yang, internal-external pairing, AND six-meridian pairing. Track which lens you're using - it matters most once you begin pattern differentiation later in the program.

The Three Jiao (Sanjiao)

Jiao	Boundary	Organ systems
Upper Jiao	Above the diaphragm	Lung, Heart, Pericardium
Middle Jiao	Diaphragm to umbilicus	Stomach, Spleen, Liver, Gallbladder
Lower Jiao	Umbilicus to pelvic floor	Kidney, Large Intestine, Small Intestine, Bladder

San Jiao (Triple Burner) is unusual: as a channel and organ system, it is its own entity - but as a spatial region, it spans all three jiao at once.

Flinner-Only: Two Pairing Systems

Do not conflate these - they answer different questions

Internal-External pairing follows circulation order (a Yin channel hands off to its paired Yang channel, back and forth around the body). Six-Meridian pairing groups channels by physiological relationship, independent of circulation order - e.g. Lung's Six-Meridian partner is Spleen (both Tai Yin), NOT Large Intestine.

Internal-External Pair	Six-Meridian Name	Element
Lung / Large Intestine	Tai Yin (LU) / Yang Ming (LI)	Metal
Stomach / Spleen	Yang Ming (ST) / Tai Yin (SP)	Earth
Heart / Small Intestine	Shao Yin (HT) / Tai Yang (SI)	Fire

Trap to watch for

BOTH

Exam trap either instructor could use: don't assume 'Internal-External partner' and 'Six-Meridian partner' are the same channel. Lung's Internal-External partner is Large Intestine; Lung's Six-Meridian (same-name, opposite-limb) partner is Spleen.

Study Strategy for Week 1

How to use this combined guide

1. Your own quizzes, midterm, and final use Dr. Zhang's framing - the Three Circuits structure and Three Functions are what you'll be tested on directly.
2. Flinner's Ying/Wei, Three Jiao, and Two-Pairing-Systems material won't appear on your exam by name, but they're useful memory scaffolds and worth knowing if you ever cross-reference with classmates in Flinner's section.
3. Treat any point-level fact that only appears in one source as unconfirmed until checked against the textbook (CAM 4th Ed. / Deadman's MOA 3rd Ed.) - this guide flags source for every claim so nothing gets silently blended.
4. Draw it, don't just read it - both instructors independently emphasize hand-drawing each circuit's four meridians as the actual retention method, not rereading.

Vocabulary Crosswalk

Chinese-Pinyin terms used across both sources

Term	Meaning
Jing (经)	Meridian - a primary pathway, 'like a river'
Luo (络)	Collateral - a branch off a meridian, 'like a branch'
Jing-Luo	Channels - the umbrella term for Meridians + Collaterals together
Zang	Yin, solid organ (Lung, Spleen, Heart, Liver, Kidney, Pericardium)
Fu	Yang, hollow organ (Large Intestine, Stomach, Small Intestine, Bladder, Gallbladder, San Jiao)
Ying qi	Nutritive qi - interior, nourishing (Flinner framing)
Wei qi	Defensive qi - exterior, protective (Flinner framing)
Sanjiao	Triple Burner/Energizer - both a channel AND a 3-part spatial region (Flinner framing)

Dr. Vivian Zhang, Ph.D. (AC300/AC375) | Dr. Justin Flinner (parallel section, cross-reference only)
Jon Centeno, D.AcHM Candidate | VUIM